

Siege of Khe Sanh

In early January 1968, the remote US combat base of Khe Sanh came under intense attack as part of the NVA's plan to divert US and allied troops from the targets of the Tet Offensive. The siege that ensued was one of the fiercest battles of the war.

◀◀ BEFORE

Khe Sanh was a US combat base in the northwest corner of South Vietnam.

FRENCH PRECEDENT

The Viet Minh's siege of the similarly isolated French army base of **Dien Bien Phu** in 1954 had ended the **First Indochina War**.

STRATEGIC VALUE

Early in the war, the **Green Berets** established a reconnaissance post at Khe Sanh, 6 miles (10 km) from the **Ho Chi Minh Trail**. In 1966, Khe Sanh was reinforced with large numbers of Marines; the Green Berets moved to Lang Vei, a few miles west.

Like other combat bases along the DMZ, Khe Sanh and the nearby Special Forces camp of Lang Vei had come under attack by communist forces through the summer and fall of 1967. US forces had successfully counterattacked, supported by aerial bombing.

There was no reason for the US to believe that the action around Khe Sanh in January 1968 would be any different from earlier battles. However, NVA commanders had something special in mind for Khe Sanh: a reprise of the legendary victory over the French at Dien Bien Phu in 1954. The geography of Khe Sanh and Dien Bien Phu was remarkably similar—isolated hilltop forts near the Laotian frontier, surrounded by old coffee plantations and jungle that favored guerrilla warfare. Hanoi also resolved that the 304th Division of the NVA—heroes of Dien Bien Phu—should be one of two NVA divisions (totaling around 18,000 troops) that would launch the strike. Two more divisions, with similar troop strength, were positioned to block Route 9, the only overland route to Khe Sanh from US bases on the coast.

Initial attack

Contingents of NVA troops attacked Khe Sanh on January 21—nine days before the Tet Offensive—with probes against Khe Sanh, Lang Vei, and small Marine units on the surrounding hilltops. No significant ground was gained, but the NVA destroyed the Marines' ammunition dump and other vital supplies. Khe Sanh commander Colonel David Lownds reacted to this initial assault by evacuating civilians from the area and calling in more Marines and elite ARVN Rangers, boosting allied numbers to around 6,000 men.

Over the week that followed, the communists tightened the noose around Khe Sanh and Lang Vei, creeping closer to the base's perimeter until their trenches were only 1,000 yards (900 m) from their opponents. As a prelude to a ground assault, they unleashed a massive mortar, artillery, and rocket barrage on the American positions.

Low cloud and fog impeded close US air support, allowing the NVA to capture the road between the two bases, thus isolating Lang Vei. But the US airlift continued whenever weather permitted, the airplanes and helicopters dodging incoming fire.